



Q: In terms of feedstock, how are you keeping your factories running? Is there an issue with LNG (liquefied natural gas)?

A: The good thing is that none of our plants needs LNG. We pretty much run through steam, even in Kakinada (Andhra Pradesh), which is one of our main plants and will be the largest phosphatic plant in India. We are generating steam by making sulphuric acid.

Q: Tell us a little bit more about that because you are an integrated player, and that gives you a unique positioning.

A: Coromandel has taken a position to serve farmers with a range of products. We have our fertiliser, which is a key farm input. Then, there is crop protection, where we acquired Nagarjuna Agrochem recently to solidify our base. With our crop protection company, we are the third-largest in the business. Apart from this, we have our own retail stores, bio products and nano products.

Q: How do you see the overall agricultural story playing out from here on, not just in the near term but also over the longer term?

A: Agriculture, from what I have seen over the last few years, is about tech and digital. It's going right down to the farmer. Youngsters are coming into agriculture, and I did not really expect that. They have embraced digital, artificial intelligence (AI), IoT and drones. That is very encouraging. I came into this

business from Cholamandalam and never thought agriculture could be so interesting.

I can talk about drones since we have invested in a drone company. In the first year, when we tried telling farmers to use drones, we did about 40,000 acres. That was about two-and-a-half years ago. This year, we are talking about a million acres, through Coromandel's drone network.

Q: What is the biggest challenge and opportunity that you see?

A: The challenge is raw material availability. The current risks can happen any time and any place. Equally, there are opportunities in an industry that is now huge.

If you look at the Polavaram project in Andhra Pradesh, it is changing the number of acres that are getting sown. That improves output, and the government is looking at this district-wise and planning

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different products. It could be fruits and vegetables in Rayalaseema. It's not just about growing paddy or anything like that, and that is really encouraging. I see a lot of opportunity in this industry.

Q: Do you think the market is overreacting, especially in the fertiliser space, given the comfort that you mentioned on inventories, raw material and finished products?

A: We are adequately covered. Sometimes artificial stocking takes place. People get worried and try to stock and that happens in any industry. A couple of things make this industry different. In fertilisers or crop protection, it's about those few days, and if you don't have that product, then you lose the crop. Overall, I don't see a problem in the first quarter or for the first sowing season. **BT**

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